SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #28 · SIN

“A good Christian always feels guilty.”

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Where it often comes from

Teaching that stressed sin and unworthiness far more than grace and joy. Feeling that relaxing or being happy is spiritually careless. Believing that constant guilt keeps you humble or safe. A family where guilt was used to control behavior. Fear that if you stop feeling bad, you will stop trying to do right.

What Scripture teaches

God wants His children to live in the freedom and joy of forgiveness, not under constant guilt. Blessed is the one whose sins are forgiven and covered. Christ set us free for freedom, and if the Son sets you free, you are free indeed. Paul tells believers to rejoice in the Lord always. Godly sorrow over sin is healthy, but it leads to repentance and then to joy, not to a lifetime of shame.

> *“Blessed is he whose transgressions are forgiven, whose sins are covered. Blessed is the man whose iniquity the LORD does not count against him, in whose spirit there is no deceit”* **(Psalm 32:1–2)**.

Also see

> “It is for freedom that Christ has set us free. Stand firm, then, and do not be encumbered once more by a yoke of slavery” **(Galatians 5:1)**.

> “So if the Son sets you free, you will be free indeed” **(John 8:36)**.

> “Rejoice in the Lord always. I will say it again: Rejoice!” **(Philippians 4:4)**.

> “Restore to me the joy of Your salvation, and sustain me with a willing spirit” **(Psalm 51:12)**.

Common self-statements

- If I don’t feel guilty, I must be proud.
- Feeling bad keeps me humble.
- Joy is for people who don’t take sin seriously.
- I don’t deserve to feel at peace.
- God expects me to keep feeling sorry.
- A good Christian is always aware of how bad he is.

Common logical errors

- **Should statements:** “I should always feel guilty to be a good Christian.”
- **Confusing humility with shame:** Believing that feeling bad about yourself is the same as being humble.
- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Thinking you must either feel guilty or not care about sin.
- **Mental filter:** Focusing on sin while ignoring forgiveness, freedom, and joy.
- **Emotional reasoning:** Concluding “If I feel peace, I must be doing something wrong.”

Challenging questions

- Who does Psalm 32 call blessed: the guilty or the forgiven?
- What did Christ set me free for?
- If Scripture tells me to rejoice always, why would God want me to feel guilty always?
- Is constant guilt making me more like Christ, or more anxious?
- What is the difference between godly sorrow and ongoing shame?
- Who taught me that guilt equals goodness?
- What would joyful obedience look like for me?

Truth summary

> A good Christian does not have to feel guilty all the time. God forgives and covers my sin, and He wants me to live in freedom and joy. Godly sorrow leads me to repentance and then to peace. I can take sin seriously and still rejoice in the Lord, because Christ has set me free.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Joy
- Forgiveness
- Guilt/Shame
- Grace
- Peace

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "A good Christian always feels guilty"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"A good Christian always feels guilty." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who does Psalm 32 call blessed?
- ☐ What did Christ set me free for?
- ☐ Why would God want me to feel guilty if He says rejoice?
- ☐ Is constant guilt making me more like Christ?
- ☐ Godly sorrow or ongoing shame: which is this?
- ☐ Who taught me that guilt equals goodness?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Blessed is the one whose sins are forgiven.
- ☐ Christ set me free to live in freedom.
- ☐ I can take sin seriously and still rejoice.
- ☐ Godly sorrow leads to repentance and then to peace.
- ☐ God wants me to know the joy of His salvation.
- ☐ If the Son sets me free, I am free indeed.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Psalm 32:1–2**
  "Blessed is he whose transgressions are forgiven, whose sins are covered. Blessed is the man whose iniquity the LORD does not count against him, in whose spirit there is no deceit."
- [ ] **Galatians 5:1**
  "It is for freedom that Christ has set us free. Stand firm, then, and do not be encumbered once more by a yoke of slavery."
- [ ] **John 8:36**
  "So if the Son sets you free, you will be free indeed."
- [ ] **Philippians 4:4**
  "Rejoice in the Lord always. I will say it again: Rejoice!"
- [ ] **Psalm 51:12**
  "Restore to me the joy of Your salvation, and sustain me with a willing spirit."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Joy log:** Each day, write one thing I enjoyed and thank God for it without apologizing.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, John 8:36 becomes: "So if the Son sets **Sarah** free, **she** will be free indeed."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Joy" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Plan one enjoyable activity this week** and do it without guilt, thanking God for it.
- ☐ **Read Psalm 32 aloud,** and circle every word about joy, blessing, or gladness.
- ☐ **When guilt shows up for no clear reason, say:** "I have been forgiven. I choose to rejoice," then continue what you were doing.
- ☐ **Ask a joyful Christian you respect** how they hold sin seriously and still live with joy.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "A good Christian always feels guilty": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One thing I enjoyed without guilt
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~A good Christian always feels guilty.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, thank You that You forgive and cover my sin. Help me reject the lie that a good Christian always feels guilty. Restore to me the joy of Your salvation. Teach me to take sin seriously, to repent quickly, and to live in the freedom Christ won for me. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.